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Ruth & Bucky Pizzarelli

Ruth and Bucky Pizzarelli are New Jersey natives and have experienced a long and successful life in music. They raised four productive children, two of whom are professional musicians. They also have four grandchildren.

Ruth and Bucky were interviewed in Saddle River, NJ, on January 19, 2015 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive. Romy Britell participated briefly in the interview.

BP: Ask me the first question.

RP: Is it true or false?

MR: That's great. Okay. My name is Monk Rowe and I'm privileged to be here at the Pizzarelli home in Saddle River, New Jersey. And you wanted to start with some true or false questions. Okay.

BP: Right.

MR: All right here's one: the life of a musician is easy?

BP: False.

MR: Why?

RP: Not so bad.

MR: It's not so bad?

BP: Well I mean we're expected to do so much every time we appear somewhere, especially on a recording session. And sometimes you don't meet those specifications.

MR: Sometimes who doesn't make the specifications?

BP: Well you don't. Yourself. I mean they want certain things and you have to be ready to do that. So that's a tough job for a musician.

MR: How do you get that preparation? You just learn it on the job?

BP: Yeah, yeah. They want more than what you have.

MR: Okay. And sometimes do you have producers who don't really know what they want?

BP: And you give them more than they think they're getting.

MR: Okay. Well I really wanted to talk some more today about just following up — I know you did an awful lot of studio work. And Ruth you were talking about waiting for the husbands to get home?

BP: The water was still boiling.

MR: What was that like?

RP: It was lonely. I mean I had the children, thank goodness. But he was gone all week long and then maybe Saturday night we could get to go out if we had a sitter, babysitters. But I remember Dominick Cortese and his wife and somebody would have a party. It was like wow, we're going out tonight.

MR: That's interesting that you say on Saturday night, because where I'm from, in Upstate New York, Saturday night is usually a night you'd be working. But during the studio years that might not have been — unless you had a jazz gig or something.

RP: Well it wasn't every Saturday night. But when the wives got together it was so much fun, and we could all give our point of view about this — I'd hate to say our husbands — but we'd always start to talk, "well what does he do," — "well he does this, you know" and, "oh no, he never does that." So we all had a little clique going there.

MR: What kind of things would a wife say, "he never does that" meaning what?

BP: It would be all different things. It's not just music. It might be gardening or it might be —

MR: Oh I see what you're talking about.

RP: Oh, he loves that" and I said, "oh I love that," "oh my husband would never do that. You know, stuff like that.

MR: Stuff like who's at home, who balances the checkbook, who balances the checkbook in your family?

RP: I did, up until recently. No but I did because we were just married and I think I had Ann already though, we lived in Clifton. And I always remember doing, he gave me, "here, you do it, the bank. Checking, cash and what was the other one, there was three of them, and we'd know exactly — savings, cash and checking. But anyway he'd give me the checks and whatever and I would sit at the kitchen table and do cash and this — and not even thinking of like gee we'd better put twenty dollars away or fifty dollars or a hundred. Don't you think we ought to — no, we just automatically did savings, cash and I can't think of what the other one was.

MR: I won't tell the IRS but did you always put down the cash gigs?

BP: Well there weren't any cash gigs.

MR: There weren't any cash gigs.

BP: It was all done through the union you know. Then when you'd go to the union to pick up the checks that you did for a month, and you had to pay them a tax.

MR: Did you keep a personal record like okay I played 14 dates in the last two weeks, and then eventually you're going to the union to get the checks and did you say, okay now everything is accounted for?

BP: That's the way it worked, yes. Sometimes they weren't there if they were late.

MR: All right. What is it like doing taxes for the Pizzarelli family? Is it complicated?

BP: I would say not that complicated.

RP: Why?

BP: Well you make so much and you've got to pay so much.

MR: Yeah but you get income from so many different places.

BP: Well they all send you slips.

MR: That's true.

BP: See when you do a recording date, you've got to sign a slip. Even one date, they send you a slip.

MR: So you're saying during the "glory years" of the studio, what years did that encompass?

BP: For me?

MR: Yes.

BP: Oh I would say from late 50s, all of the 60s, into the 70s, like '70, '71, '72.

MR: Did you decide to get out of it or did it just sort of —

BP: No it left me.

MR: It dried up. And why did it dry up?

BP: I don't know why. Because all of a sudden there weren't any calls coming in. You know I was just sitting home waiting for calls and they never showed up. That's how I started playing live again.

MR: Oh that's so interesting to me.

BP: Well I figured the life of a musician comes in phases. It started with the big bands for me. I thought when the band broke up that was the end of the world. It wasn't. I went on staff, I did the "Kate Smith Show." While I was on the "Kate Smith Show" I subbed for the guitar player on the Three Suns, Morty (sic) [Al] Nevins, and I took his place. I put his tux on and I appeared as him. And I ended up playing with them for two years. I went to Vegas the first six weeks we were married we were in Vegas and we played from midnight to five in the morning.

MR: How did you two meet?

BP: My sister was a nurse at St. Joe's Hospital. And she was working at the emergency room. And Ruth baby here, was there too.

RP: I worked there with his sister.

BP: So she saw me and she fell in love with me.

RP: No that's not quite right.

MR: I thought we'd get a couple of those moments here. Okay so Ruth, how did you meet?

RP: I was a registered nurse at St. Joseph's Hospital in Paterson, New Jersey, and I had just graduated. It was in 1951, '52, something like that. And I happened to look — I was on duty and I happened to look up, and sitting on the bench, they had a little bench outside the admitting department. And I had to go out and say, "may I help you." So I walked out and this wonderful looking man, oh beautifully dressed, and I went out and I said, "may I help you." And he said, "I'm waiting for my sister, Marie Pizzarelli." "Oh, yes, just a moment please." So I went back and I said, "Marie, is that your brother?" And she said, "oh is he here?" "Oh, okay." Left it go. Next day he was back again. So I walked out. Because Marie told me he was a celebrity. So I walked out and said, "your sister told me

you're a celebrity and you worked with Vaughan Monroe, my favorite, my sister and I." It was bliss. And so after that I was still living in the nursing school home and the phone rang while I was waiting for my brother to come pick me up to go home. And the phone rang, and it was Marie saying, and I happened to be there — I went to the phone, Marie said, "oh Ruth, my brother wants to talk to you" meaning Mr. Pizzarelli. He said, "hi Ruth, would you like to go out tonight?" I said, "oh I'd love to but I can't go because my brother is picking me up with his car to take me home." And you know what Bucky said? "Tell him to go home." So I did. And that was our first date. And it was wonderful. Everything was good. My mother gave us a little trouble, because he was a musician, and marijuana was in the thing. And Gene Krupa.

MR: Gene Krupa. He had been arrested.

BP: Yeah, yeah, yeah.

RP: And very sad.

MR: But what about also, let's say, the prospects of being a musician. Are you going to be able to make a good living. Was that an issue?

BP: Well you had to be with a big band to get a little work.

MR: Okay so that was 1940—

RP: About '51.

BP: I was finished with the big band. Vaughan broke up then. I went back to New York and luckily I got a job as a staff musician playing for the "Kate Smith Show."

MR: So what network was that on?

BP: NBC.

MR: Wow. How did you get that?

BP: We did a radio show with Vaughan Monroe and we had violins just for the show. And I met one of the cello players on the street and he said to me — Brownie, his name was Brown — he said, "they're looking for a guitar player at NBC. Tell them I sent you up." And I used his name and I got the job without auditioning or anything. And I did it for a whole year, her last year on television.

MR: And you were expected to be able to sight read, chords and —

BP: Yeah. A little solo here and there.

MR: Do you remember what that paid?

BP: $250 a week.

MR: That's not bad.

BP: That was good then.

MR: Five days a week?

BP: Five days a week. Whether you were there or not.

MR: Whether you were there or not?

BP: Well if you had a day off or a week off, if you went to California, you still got paid as a staff musician.

MR: All right. And meanwhile you have a growing family, right?

BP: Yeah.

MR: So were there tough years financially?

BP: No I don't think so, not with that kind of a gig. That solved all of the problems.

MR: That's nice.

RP: We never fought over money. We were very happy.

MR: Did you ever have a moment in your life, from the time of Vaughan Monroe on, where you felt I have to do something else?

BP: No. I always wanted to play the guitar and that was it. And I never thought of any other thing. I couldn't do anything else but play the guitar.

MR: Okay. I'm going to play a little Name That Tune.

BP: All right.

MR: We'll see how long it takes you to recognize —

[audio interlude]

BP: Who is it?

MR: You know who this is, that's you playing.

BP: Dion.

MR: Dion.

BP: Well we did those tunes never thinking, but when we'd hear them again we didn't believe that we were on the record. That's how many record dates we did.

MR: I want you to tell me more about that because I just think it's very interesting.

BP: They hired Al Ciola, me and I think it was Dick Hyman or somebody playing the piano, just to be on a record date.

MR: Who hires you for this kind of thing?

BP: The company. What was the name of the record company. Anyway they say that's what we want. And Dion would come and dictate what he wanted us to do.

MR: Who would?

BP: Dion.

MR: Oh, okay.

BP: He was a guitar player too. He had a couple of strums that he showed me that I did. And he was very good at that.

MR: So on the date there would have been a drummer? Do you remember who played on that?

BP: Oh yeah, Panama Francis.

MR: Okay. And a bass player. What kind of bass would it have been?

BP: [sounds like] Brad Carroll. Upright.

MR: Upright. And a couple of guitars.
BP: Yeah.
MR: And you just ran the tune down?
BP: That's all.
MR: Was he singing?
BP: Yeah. He sang.
MR: It was all live?
BP: Yeah. He was good. He was a top rate professional singer.
MR: Was there overdubbing to be done, because there's like these background vocals.
BP: A little here and there.
MR: And there's a sax solo in there.
BP: King Curtis played the sax.
MR: You know you see the videos of these bands and they have all these young men playing, so most of those guys weren't on the records, right? When you see the album cover of Dion and the Belmonts or whatever, or you see a video of them like on the oldies channel, and they're playing the song — they might be playing it live but most of those fellas weren't on the record, right?
BP: No. They just showed a band, that's all.
MR: So why didn't the record companies have a band come in and play? I mean this could be an obvious question.
BP: For the picture or for the sound?
MR: For the record. Why did they hire you guys instead of the guys in Dion's band?
BP: Well we were hot, we made a lot of records. So they said, "get that guy that does all the records." That's the way it worked.
MR: So Ruth, when Bucky came home, either that night after a day in the studios, or the next morning, did you do a like, "well how was your day? What happened yesterday?" Would you do that kind of thing?
RP: No I didn't do that kind of thing. I had kids running, and I had to go do food shopping, I had to find out what he was going to do, was he coming home tonight, tomorrow and on and on. That's what I did. I had to take them to school.
MR: Do you remember what kind of event in his day might have come up as something that was really interesting. What might he have talked about that was worth —
RB: Significant.
MR: Significant. That was worth hearing about.
RP: Sinatra I guess.
BP: Yeah. I made that record date with Frank Sinatra.
MR: It took that much, to get to Sinatra.

BP: No but when John was born I was doing an album with Panama Francis. And that day that John was born we had the wrong music for the band that was there. We were supposed to have strings and we had a brass band there. And naturally we had to shift gears you know, and get all the music for the band that was supposed to be on the record, as opposed to what was there. So that's why I missed the whole birth.

RP: See what he was getting to?

MR: You weren't there when John was born?

BP: No. I could have been.

RP: He comes into the room — you could turn it off if you want.

MR: That's all right.

RP: But he comes into the room and, "did you have the baby" or something like that. "Yeah. We had a boy." So that was the beginning. And then we had Martin after that so we had two girls first and then the two boys. But I think I even spoke to Milt about it or one of them — or Panama Francis. Yeah. I said, "you know I had the baby."

MR: And Bucky was with you, right?

RP: Right.

MR: You know nowadays we're so used to being able to connect immediately — get your cell phone and you could at least say, "I'm not going to get there." Right? But that wasn't the case back then.

BP: I was there already with the wrong music, so that made a big delay.

MR: I see.

BP: We corrected it.

MR: Logistically I picture you and that crew going from one place to another in Manhattan. Did you have instruments and amps waiting for you?

BP: We had amps, because all of the guitar players got together and decided to supply every studio with three amplifiers, Ampegs. We knew the guy who made them. It was good.

MR: Okay.

BP: So we all got together and we had a slush fund and we bought amps for every studio. And that stopped us from carrying a guitar and a banjo and a ukulele and an amp.

MR: You know Panama Francis said something about — some people didn't like the fact that he was playing rock & roll, the jazz people would make fun of him or would look —

BP: Oh yeah, yeah, yeah.

MR: Is that right?

BP: Yeah. Well, "oh he's a rock & roller."

MR: Do you think some of them were jealous that he was making good money doing that?

BP: Well he was making good money but he was a good drummer. You take a guy like Pretty [Bernard] Purdie, he was a good drummer no matter where he was: rock & roll or swing, he could do everything.

MR: He said some nice things about you you know.

BP: Who?

MR: Bernard Purdie.

BP: Oh yeah?

MR: He did. He said that you sort of saved him a few times, I think because — he had high opinions, right?

BP: Yeah.

MR: In the studio? Like this should be done this way.

BP: Yeah.

MR: I don't know, he gave me the impression that you helped him not get in trouble.

BP: Yeah, well, in other words, when I heard him play on a ship he was playing in a jam session one night. I said, "who the hell is that drummer?" It was Pretty Purdie. And he was swinging. So we used him on a record date, John and I. He played "Sing Sing Sing" — it was unbelievable. He knew it backwards.

MR: All right, I'm going to try another tune on you here. I'm just going to give you — [audio interlude]

MR: Do you remember that one? You don't remember it.

RP: Who was it?

MR: You told me that you played on this song.

BP: Oh yeah, the Itsy Bitsy.

MR: Okay so you do this date. I mean that's kind of a corny song.

BP: Yeah, yeah. That's what the business was.

MR: When you guys had a break, let's say you had two hours, and I know you usually went into practice your acoustic guitar. But if you were hanging out in a bar or something, did you talk about this music?

BP: No. No we never did. We didn't even know what we did. And then when it came out it was a big hit, I said wow.

MR: Isn't that something.

BP: And we did it every day. Every day. We made demos. The demos were what they used for a real track.

MR: Right. They just were doing these scratch things and then they ended up using it.

BP: Yeah, when the songwriters wrote the song we had to go do what they call a demo. It paid 30 bucks. And they give it to the publisher. The publisher would — say if the demo was real good they'd say to the arranger, "do it like this."

MR: Oh that is so interesting. It's like backwards almost.

BP: Yeah, yeah, yeah. And nine times out of ten they used the sound of the demo on the track.

MR: Wow. Okay so then a couple of months later you hear this thing on the radio and you go, "gee that sounds familiar" and you're playing on it. But you didn't make any more money if a song became a hit.

BP: No. We made nothing.

MR: Wow. Ruth, do you remember like he might be in a car and Bucky might say, "oh I played on that?"

RP: Once in a while. Not very often.

RB: What was your best time? What was your heyday or is it now?

RP: When we went six weeks to Europe with Benny [Goodman].

BP: Yeah, that was it.

RP: Bucky and I and the band. And my mother took care of the children. We lived across the street then. And I was so homesick. So I called her home from England, I said, "Ma, do you want me to come home? I'm here in London and I can get a flight home." And she said, "Ruth stay. Have a good time, enjoy. We are fine." She wouldn't let me go home. I wanted to go home. I was homesick.

RB: When was this?

BP: 26 cities in Europe with an all-English band with Benny.

RP: It was in the late 50s or early 60s?

BP: I think it was '70.

RP: 70s?

MR: So the kids were —

BP: They were okay.

MR: They were okay, sure.

RP: They weren't babies, but they went to school right here in town. And my mother loved it. And even the kids said they had such a good time with her. And they'll never forget it. And six weeks — and it was really great. Benny was very nice to us. And he visited us after.

BP: Yeah he came and slept here a few times.

MR: So that was one of the good old days. Were there bad old days?

BP: No I don't think so.

MR: There wasn't like tough years?

RP: You know we just do it.

BP: I went from one phase to another and that was a little different.

RP: For you.

BP: Yeah. For me.

MR: Yeah. Ruth for you it was pretty much the same.

BP: Yeah. Same thing.

RP: Yeah. We both seemed to know this is his work, we have the children, and this is our life. And so that's — we really didn't complain —

BP: Oh no, never.

RP: I must say we really — or fought or anything. But everybody just, we all got along. Even the kids, the kids were great. And they didn't get to see him that often. And they just basically understood what was going on and it was okay.

MR: Dad's got a gig.

BP: Yeah, that's it.

RP: Yeah. He's working for us. Look, we have a nice home, we're doing well, our health is good. We couldn't complain about anything really. Did I ever complain?

BP: No.

MR: What would have impressed, let's say during the years where most of your kids were like junior high age. Was there anything you were doing that would impress them?

RP: That would impress them?

MR: That would impress the kids.

RP: Oh well, look what happened.

BP: Well we played for the president, a couple of presidents. And it was with Reagan first with Sinatra and with Benny Goodman, Buddy Rich playing drums, Milt Hinton, Hank Jones on piano. And then another one was with —

RP: Pertini.

BP: Oh Pertini.

RP: That was with Sinatra.

BP: That was with Sinatra.

MR: Pertini?

BP: The president of Italy. He was a guest. So Tony Mottola and I got together and we made up an Italian medley. And that was big. I have a picture of that, a movie of it.

MR: You know you mention the Italian thing and I thought of you both on Christmas day, because I put on John's Christmas CD. And I remember when I put it on I was thinking, I wonder what it's like in the Pizzarelli house today. Do you have big gatherings?

BP: Well we used to have fish dinners on Christmas eve. That was a big thing. My sister used to make twelve different fish.

RP: But the next day after dinner, we would all sit in the living room and we had the piano there, John had the guitar, Martin had the bass, and Mary would play the piano, and John is telling a story and Mary's playing the background on the piano.

BP: Yeah, oh wow.

RP: I wish we had had it recorded because it was so funny, and none of us will ever, ever forget it. So we all try every year. We sing carols and stuff like that. But that was the funniest thing. And John can be very funny. And Martin gets a chance to play the bass.

RB: Did you have misgivings about the children taking up this life?

BP: Oh no, not at all.

RP: Not at all.

RB: Is that true, Ruth?

MR: About your own children becoming musicians or deciding to try to make a living in it.

RP: Oh, they're doing very well, really. And the girls, they're not musicians but they're doing okay. I think the boys are happy doing what they're doing. And I think it's just meant to be because his uncles and everything.

MR: Your family was musical also?

BP: Yes.

RP: My family?

BP: No my family.

MR: Your family.

BP: My family. My two uncles.

RP: Yeah. His uncles.

BP: Bobby and Peter Domenick.

RP: No mine were not.

MR: So I just wondered if, you're marrying a musician, you know.

RP: I had it a little tough there with my mother for a while.

MR: Yeah?

RP: Because of the things that were in the newspaper, Gene Krupa for instance. But I must say he handled it beautifully.

MR: All right.

RP: He really did.

MR: This may be an obvious question by why during the 40s and 50s especially, musicians, especially jazz musicians, had that reputation you know. They either drank or they were doing drugs or whatever. Why? Why did they do it or why was it —

BP: I don't know. Every time a big band had a day off they all got into trouble. Because all the junkies would come and serve them for nothing. You know what I mean? And that's why a lot of big bands, a lot of those guys died early. That's my conception.

MR: Because there was people out there waiting —

BP: Yeah, waiting for you to show up. When you were working you couldn't get in trouble, you had to play.

MR: I see.

BP: When you had a day off, forget it.
MR: Okay well when I came in I saw this music by Mario Tedesco —
BP: Castelnuovo.
MR: Castelnuovo. A nice Irish boy.
BP: Newcastle.
MR: Well it reminded me of this. See if you recognize this one.
[audio interlude "First Time Ever I Saw Your Face"]
MR: Did you get it yet? That's you on acoustic guitar?
BP: Get out of here. What am I playing? Oh yeah.
MR: That was kind of a different date.
BP: Yeah. Well they asked me to do something without the music, and that's what I did.
MR: You mean you had no music?
BP: Well we had just the chords but they wanted something. That's what I worked up.
MR: It was pretty good. Now do you recall coming home from — was that like a New York date?
BP: Yeah. It was an overdub. She had already made the record.
MR: Oh it was an overdub.
BP: And she wanted something different.
MR: Okay. Were you hearing her singing?
BP: Yeah. And I played like I was accompanying her.
MR: Oh. See, that's the backstory. That's very interesting. Did you come home and say, "I just played on a hit"?
BP: No.
MR: Have you ever known you were playing on a hit?
BP: No.
MR: Gee. That's very interesting.
RP: And who's the fella that played the piano that you worked with also.
BP: Ray Charles?
RP: Ray Charles, yeah.
MR: Yeah. You played on "Georgia."
BP: Yeah. "Georgia on My Mind."
MR: Well what was so special about what you played? Because you told me —
BP: I just played rhythm on that with "Georgia on My Mind." Jump bomp-chink, bomp-chink. And Les Paul called me and said, "boy is that you on it." He recognized it. Boy he loved it.
MR: Was the whole group there? Because that song had strings on it and all that.
BP: Yeah.

MR: It was recorded live?

BP: I don't know, you know there's some doubt of who made the record I think, it was either Al Cohn or somebody like that.

MR: Ralph Burns maybe?

BP: Yeah Ralph Burns. And those guys used to farm stuff out, they had so many dates, that they would call two other arrangers, "help me out here." That's the way it was.

MR: And most of those arrangers and most of those musicians, including yourself, came out of the big band era, right.

BP: Right. Every one.

MR: Every one. Was there — do you remember any conversation about having to play different for the rock & roll dates?

BP: Well we knew it was a different kind of sound. You had a guitar with a high pitch electric sound, real high. You knew how to do it. Sometimes we'd go on a date and we'd all make up a thing. One would do [scats] with your wrist on the strings, you get a real muffled sound. That was the most popular way of doing it.

MR: Has a discography been kept on you? I mean I know you can see like all the albums under your names, you know, all the Arbors Records and all that. But is there any kind of record?

BP: No. I don't know. Maybe. I couldn't tell.

MR: Sounds like some kind of project for somebody to do. Okay so this is sort of an obvious question. But why did you and Barry Galbraith and Milt Hinton, how come you were on the A team? Why was it that you got the calls?

BP: I don't know, because I thought maybe because I played rhythm guitar, and there was always room on a recording session to play rhythm. And that's what I was known for. Al Caiola and Tony Mottola were known for soloists. George Barnes as a soloist. If they didn't need a soloist they wouldn't hire them. They just had rhythm guitar. That's one thing they had to have on a record. Bomp-chink, bomp-chink. And that I knew I could do very well.

MR: Did Freddie Green hip you to that?

BP: Well I followed what Freddie did. But I also knew what Barry Galbraith did. I mean he was with Claude Thornhill's band and it was superb playing. And I got to know him very well. We played together. We were on the Wrigley Spearmint Gum commercial. Double Your Pleasure or something like that.

MR: Double your pleasure, double your fun, with —

RP: Doublemint Gum.

BP: We made a lot of money on that date.

MR: How come?

BP: Well they played it — Super Bowl Sunday came around and we ended up with five thousand dollars in the mailbox.

MR: I was going to ask you — do checks still show up for things you did years ago?

BP: No, not like that, not with that price tag on it.

MR: Okay but do you get some mysterious checks sometimes?

BP: Yeah, yeah, yeah. Well I mean I did a lot of soap operas, what was the Irish one there, "Ryan's Hope." And they released all the stuff that I was on and they played them all again. I made a lot of money.

MR: Nice. It's nice when the system works like that right?

BP: Yeah.

MR: Like ASCAP or whatever it is. So Ruth, did you get to go on these jazz party things? Did you want to?

RP: Oh yeah. Texas.

BP: Yeah that's still going.

MR: Oh, Odessa, right?

BP: Odessa and Midland. It's the same one.

RP: We had a lot of friends and we always had a good time. Very nice. We went a long time.

MR: And the one in —

BP: Denver?

MR: Denver. They made that movie that we watched.

BP: Yeah, yeah.

MR: That was an incredible assemblage of musicians.

BP: Did you see that movie?

MR: Yes. I could not believe —

BP: Yeah, Ruby Braff starts it off, doesn't he?

MR: Yeah. And was there people like, let's say Phil Woods. If Phil Woods came to that thing would you guys be saying he's a little modern for this.

BP: No I wouldn't say that. The way he played, that was great.

MR: And now, when I was listening to you talk with Julia and Dick Hyman, Julia was talking about the studio days and she said to Dick, "you never turned anything down."

BP: That's right.

MR: And Ruth, you said to Bucky, "and neither did you."

BP: Yeah, yeah, yeah.

MR: But John said, in an interview I saw, let's see if I can find this, "my father worked his ass off but he never did anything he didn't like.

BP: Yeah. Well when they hire you you don't know what you have to play. You know what I mean?

MR: Yes.

BP: So after the day you may say what the hell did I do, I shouldn't have taken this. But you still got paid.

MR: Okay. Was there anything that you would say no to the next time around?

BP: No, not really.

MR: I remember this kind of music from my parents' house. I'm not sure you're on this but it wouldn't surprise me.

[audio interlude]

BP: Who's that?

MR: It's called "Guitars Unlimited."

BP: West coast.

MR: Oh it's west coast.

BP: Yeah.

MR: Okay well why do you know that?

BP: Well we know when certain things come out where they're from you know. They made a couple of records out there with five guitars. It was a rarity to have someone do that. That was the west coast. Who was that by the way?

MR: I think it was Tommy Tedesco maybe.

BP: Yeah.

MR: It was called "Espresso."

BP: Yeah, yeah, yeah.

MR: It was actually tough music to play and the woodwinds are going [scats].

BP: Yeah, yeah, yeah. Tedesco is the Tony Mottola of the west coast.

MR: I see. Wow. You know you've done a lot of interviews. In fact this is our third one. Is there ever a question that nobody asks that you'd like to talk about.

BP: I don't know.

MR: What's your take on jazz education?

BP: That's a good question. I mean the kids all go to music school today, and what they got out of it, I got more out of not going to school for music. There's a way of doing it.

RP: But you had your uncles.

BP: I had my uncles show me, and I knew the good musicians in Paterson, and I learned from them more than anybody else.

MR: Do you think that can still happen these days?

BP: Yes.

MR: I wanted to go back to, Ruth, something you said when the contractors called the house looking for Bucky that sometimes they didn't really want to talk to you. How come, do you know?

BP: Well they don't want to give the information to the wife, thinking that the wife won't tell the husband.

RP: No, they made me feel like I didn't know what to do or how to say it or who to get, and they'd say no, I'll call back. It didn't happen very often.

BP: When you hire someone you've got to go direct.

MR: Yeah. Like they want to know you've got to bring your Strat or whatever.

RB: Well did you ever feel like you might be losing out on work because he wasn't there to get that call?

BP: Oh no, no, no. Never, never.

MR: Was this the Radio Registry?

BP: Yeah.

RP: They were all right. They were pretty good.

MR: So after a date ended, if you had a 10-1 or something and you had an hour, did you head for the phones to check in.

BP: Yeah. I always checked in with her.

MR: Nowadays everybody's texting.

RP: Right.

MR: But you guys had to find a pay phone, right?

BP: That's right.

MR: How did it ever happen before cell phones?

RP: I don't know how they did it.

MR: Do you have a sense of what the studio thing is like now?

BP: It's gone. The studio thing is gone. They make records, but you can buy any record you want cheaper on the internet. You know what I mean?

RB: Download it.

BP: That's right. That put us out of business. You play in a nightclub and they have something that they call streaming. It goes all over the country.

MR: That's right. You mentioned Small's, that club?

BP: Yeah, they did it.

MR: You can get on at night and you can watch who's playing there, from wherever you are. Well do you think technology has been a blessing or a curse?

BP: It killed us.

RP: What?

BP: It killed us.

RP: Well, times march on.

BP: Yeah, that's right. If you don't play a record date and you play a gig, like I did last night, I enjoy doing that more than I do a record date, playing live.

MR: But you took, what was it a couple of hours, the gig was, two or three hours?

BP: That's all. Two hours last night.

MR: But you had to leave an hour and a half before it started.

BP: Oh yeah, the weather was bad last night.

MR: Okay. But that's part of the life, right?

BP: Yeah, yeah.

MR: Yeah, that's part of the — how did you learn all those songs that you know?

BP: Number one, I can fake a lot of them. You know what I mean?

MR: Sort of.

BP: If you're playing the piano and I have to follow you I can do it.

MR: Okay. But somebody needs to know, right? Hopefully the bass player, right?

BP: Yeah I have to know the songs — I learn the songs according to the composers. You get all the Richard Rodgers songs and you see hey he wrote this, he wrote that, then you build a repertoire. That's the way I learned it.

MR: Do you have an opinion why most of the songs like from the *Great American Songbook* are in flat keys?

BP: No, I don't know why. Well it might be when they sell sheet music it's easier to have something that's written in the key of F than it is in the key of F sharp.

MR: True. Who wants to play that, right?

BP: It's too many sharps.

MR: A person picks up the music and goes, "naaa".

BP: Well if you look at "Stardust" it's in D flat, the original key, that's five flats. But when you buy the music sometimes it's written in C. Then the fake books come out and some wise guy puts some different chords in there that don't fit.

MR: The substitutions.

BP: Yeah.

MR: I don't know I have to say I've been able to sit beside you a couple of times playing and it's been a big thrill. And I just look at you chomping away there and there's like nothing like that.

BP: Yeah, that's the whole ball game. I think that's the most important thing in any big band was the rhythm guitar. That's what the people danced to.

MR: And sometimes you could hardly hear it.

BP: That's right. You feel it.

MR: I remember the last Fallcoming concert we did and we were playing Dick Hyman's charts.

BP: Oh yeah, yeah, yeah.

MR: And you had a really long piece. It was like five or six pages long. And I said, "Bucky do you want another stand?" And do you remember what you said?

BP: No.

MR: You said basically, naaa, I don't want a stand at all. Because you don't need a stand.

BP: I don't need it.

MR: Okay well this has just been really very interesting for me. And one last thing, see if you remember where this came from.

[audio interlude]

BP: Is that Pretty Purdie?

MR: That's you, and some other guitar player you know.

RP: John?

MR: And John.

BP: There's drums on it.

MR: No, there's no drums.

BP: No drums?

MR: That's you playing.

BP: Keep in on. Keep it on yet. Keep it on, yeah. Put it up a little.

[audio interlude]

BP: There's no drum on that, you're right.

MR: "John and Bucky Live at the Vineyard."

BP: Oh that was a long time ago.

MR: John was still in his yout. Anyway, we feel privileged to be in your house.

RP: Well I'm going to get — are you ready to have supper?

MR: We are, and thank you very much.

RP: Oh you're quite welcome.